

of the VM depends heavily on the garbage collector's performance. Another major characteristic of a language virtual machine is the instruction set exposed by the VM, and its interactions with the underlying OS and hardware. We will discuss these in next month's column.

Meanwhile, a couple of takeaway questions for our readers. We have been talking a lot about Java Virtual Machine. But we have not mentioned anything about a virtual machine for C. Are there any popular virtual machines for C? If not, why is it so? The second question is quite straightforward. Is it possible to implement a Java Virtual Machine in Java itself?

My 'must-read book' for this month

This month's 'must-read book' suggestion comes from one of our readers, Karthik B, who recommends the book 'The Pragmatic Programmer: From Journeyman to Master' by Andrew Hunt and David Thomas. As Karthik says, "This book discusses the various issues and concerns of the programmer, and provides simple techniques for efficient programming. No matter which level of programming expertise you are at, you will benefit from this book." Thank you, Karthik for the

recommendation. I have not read the book yet, but plan to do so in the coming weeks.

If you have a favourite programming book/article that you think is a must-read for every programmer, please do send me a note with the book's name, and a short write-up on why you think it is useful so I can mention it in the column. This would help many readers who want to improve their coding skills.

If you have any favourite programming puzzles that you would like to discuss on this forum, please send them to me, along with your solutions and feedback, at sandyasm_AT_yahoo_DOT_com. Till we meet again next month, happy programming and here's wishing you the very best! 

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The author is an expert in systems software and works at Hewlett-Packard India. Her interests include compilers, multi-core technologies and software development tools. If you are preparing for systems software interviews, you may find it useful to visit Sandya's LinkedIn group *Computer Science Interview Training India* at <http://www.linkedin.com/groups?home=&gid=2339182>.

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